because active-member status is a compulsory qualification for any party post. The catch was that the any 100-new-member lists claimed by an aspiring member would now be verified in the new system by higher-ups through digital and phone records.

Technology reduced the possibility of fudging and collusion by local networks of power, even as it allowed the creation of centralised databases that could be checked and rechecked for accuracy at any level, even by a distant call centre. ‘Now that system is not there that we can sit in a room, make up members, send the list up and forget about it,’ explained a district party official. ‘Now we have to give phone numbers, Aadhaar card number. It is then tallied at that end by them [higher-ups in the party]. Then a call will come from there that so-and-so’s number doesn’t tally. They actually check and send it back to us. At times, they would send the full list back—saying you have made a wrong list. People’s numbers are not tallying. People are saying no, we never joined, they put our name as a member without asking us. Then we have to make the list again. Earlier we could do a lot of farzi wara [fake scam]. That system is totally over now.’[23]

Figure 8.5: BJP Cadre Work at the Height of the Pandemic-induced Lockdown, April 2020